



Implementation plan for CoARA commitments to reform research assessment at the University of Lapland

2024-2026

1. Background

The University of Lapland joined the international Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment [CoARA](#) on November 16, 2022. Thus, we were able to take the commitments of the agreement of the coalition into account in the then ongoing [University of Lapland Research Assessment Exercise 2022–2023](#) (ed. by E. Salmenkivi, P. Falin, P. Kleemola-Juntunen, T. Saarenpää, published on September 7, 2023).

2. Guiding Principles

Guiding principles on research and researcher assessment of the University of Lapland are based on:

- [the CoARA commitments](#),
- [DORA](#),
- [The Metric Tide](#),
- [SCOPE](#),
- [Science Europe recommendations](#), and
- Finnish national recommendations in [Good Practice in researcher evaluation](#) (published in 2020)

3. The Scope

The principles encompass any **assessment of research** at the University of Lapland for the purposes of:

- allocating funding
- public investment accountability
- informing decisions on research priorities
- improving the definition and implementation of research strategies
- informing project management and future research funding decisions,
- making prize and award decisions.

The principles also encompass any **assessment of individual researchers and research teams** at the University of Lapland for the purposes of:

- allocating funding,
- recruitment and hiring promotion,



- professional development review,
- prize and award decisions



4. Responsibilities and Process

At the University of Lapland, the implementation of the CoARA commitments is led by the vice-rector for research and monitored by the Research Development Committee (TUKERY). The representative of the University of Lapland in the CoARA national chapter supports the vice-rector for research in the implementation of the commitments and the updating of this implementation plan.

The Research Development Committee has discussed the first drafts of the implementation plan in its meetings in 2023 and the beginning of 2024.

The implementation plan will be aligned with the research development plan of the University and updated regularly.

5. The planned actions

5.1. **Assessment of researchers at the University of Lapland**

The University of Lapland follows the development of national (e.g. Finnish Career Assessment Matrix, FIN-CAM) and international models (HRS4R) and strives to develop its researcher evaluation practices with their support in the context of recruitment and hiring promotion, and professional development review.

The goal is that in 2026 the university's recruitment and researcher assessment practices are in line with the realization of CoARA's core commitments.

5.2. Continuity

The predictability and prior scheduling of future assessments is one of the actions that ensures ***the commitment of resources for reforming the research assessment and the commitment to reviewing and developing research assessment criteria, tools and processes.***

Continuity of coordination of research assessments should be ensured.

In ULAP RAE 2022-23 a coordination office was established for the purposes of the particular assessment, but the continuity of this work needs to be organized for future assessments in cooperation with the doctoral school, RDI services and the library of the University of Lapland. Information on the schedule of upcoming assessments needs to be available well in advance for the whole research community. In December 2023, the Research Development Committee suggested that:

there will be a light, internal follow-up of the ULAP RAE 2022–23 in Autumn 2026, and the next research assessment exercise would take place in year 2029 or Academic year 2029–30 (the assessment period being 5 years, 2024–2028).

5.3. Defining quality and impact

In the ULAP RAE 2022-2023 it became evident that the definitions of research quality and impact to ensure the coverage of a variety of disciplines and research missions is a challenging task when aiming to recognise the diversity of research activities, outcomes and interactions. This challenge is closely connected also with our HR practices and actions at the level of researcher evaluation.



The development of our understanding of research quality and impact is a key to endorsing our ***commitment towards recognising the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research*** in accordance with the needs and nature of the research. Collaboration between the research service personnel in RDI services and the library continues to further address this challenge.

5.4. Quality of data

During the ULAP RAE 2022–2023, the University of Lapland encountered the common challenge of higher education sector world-wide, that is, the difficulty to move away from journal impact factors and various rankings of research outputs. In order to support this commitment, the quality of data provided for the research assessment purposes needs to be improved.

The university library is committed to monitoring the development of responsible use of bibliometrics in, e.g., Denmark, the Netherlands and Norway.

The quality of data is a key challenge in ***ensuring the commitment towards the responsible use of quantitative indicators*** in supporting assessment practices based on qualitative peer-review and preventing the inappropriate uses of metrics, journal impact factors and indexes.

5.5. Communication

University of Lapland needs to develop a better internal and external communication's strategy, and to improve its website for both internal and external users. It is also important to have good internal communications about research opportunities, events and successes. To this end, ULAP will renew its website in 2024–25. ULAP will also implement a university-wide annual Research Day to serve as a platform to ensure the flow of information on research topics and exchanging ideas among the whole research community.

This is in line with ***the commitment to raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use.***